I would've worried about Chels hearing any of this, but since we'd begun dating she'd been so harassed by the press that she'd completely unplugged. The papers didn't exist for her. The internet was off-limits.

The British military, however, was very plugged in. Two months after announcing my deployment, the head of the Army, General Dannatt, abruptly called it off. Besides the public threats from insurgent leaders, British intelligence learned that my photo had been distributed among a group of Iraqi snipers, with instructions that I was the "mother of all targets." These snipers were elite: they'd recently cut down six British soldiers. So the mission had simply become too dangerous, for me, for anyone who might have the bad luck to be standing next to me. I'd become, in the assessment of Dannatt and others, a "bullet magnet." And the reason, he said, was the press. In his public statement canceling my deployment, he blasted journalists for their overwrought coverage, their wild speculations, which had "exacerbated" the threat level.

Pa's staff also issued a public statement, saying I was "very disappointed," which was untrue. I was crushed. When word first reached me I was at Windsor Barracks, sitting with my guys. I took a moment to collect myself, then told them the bad news. Though we'd just spent months traveling, training together, during which we'd become brothers in arms, they were now on their own.

It wasn't simply that I felt sorry for myself. I worried about my team. Someone else would have to do my job, and I'd have to live forever with the wondering, the guilt. What if they were no good?

The following week, several papers reported that I was in deep depression. One or two, however, reported that the abrupt about-face in my deployment had been my own doing. The coward story, again. They said that, behind the scenes, I'd pressed my superiors to pull the plug.

2.